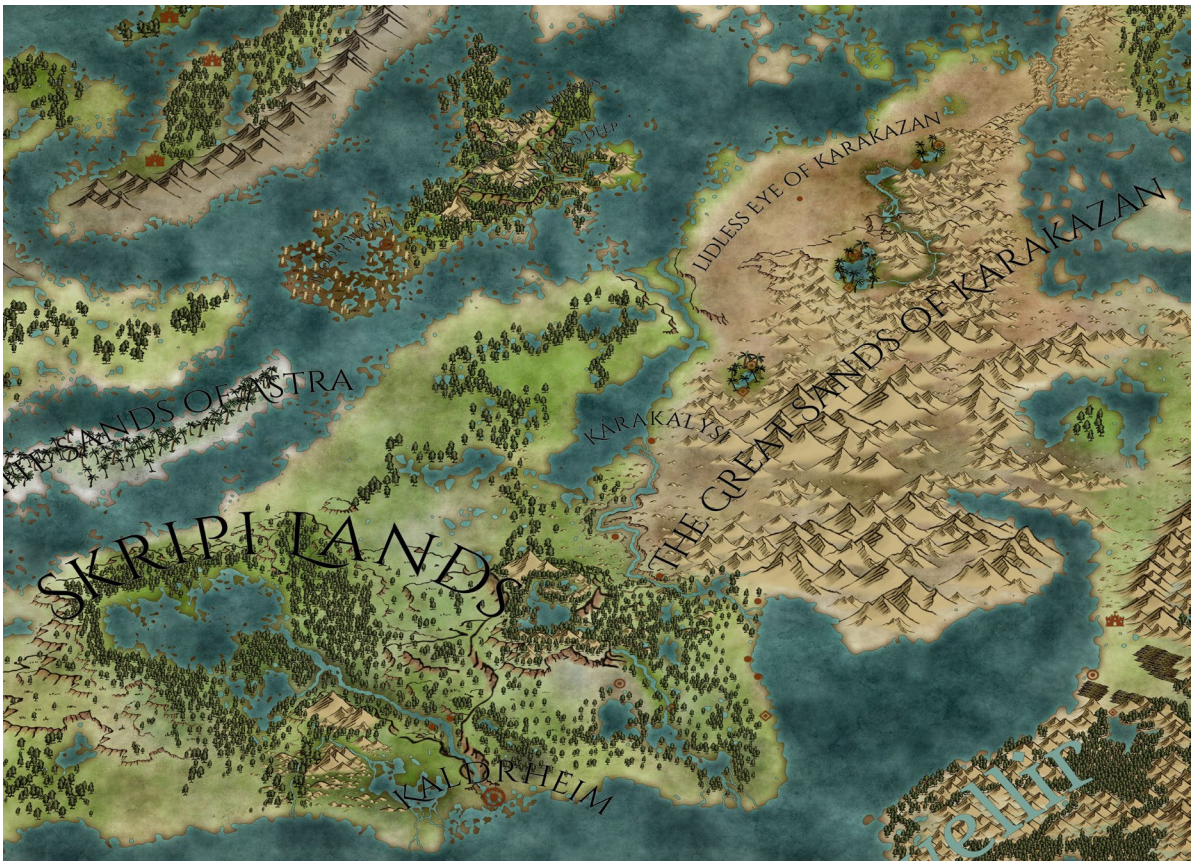

Kárakazan - Kárakalysi Province – Kárakalysi

1.1 Ragnarök

Kára could feel a bead of sweat roll down the side of her modestly oval, and sun worn face. She squinted through her sand encrusted eyelashes, out across the dune sea.

She stared off past the river in the distance. The mid-day sun pushing the desert air well into the thirty's, and as Kara looked to the brackish river, and towards the long grass, she noted that the rising air was making it, difficult, to make out anything more than a blur.

Kara sighed and pursed her chapped lips, feeling them stick together.

Ouch she thought, as her lips ripped apart. She let her fingers feel the damage before continuing to secure the simple ribbons in her hair. She had drawn her golden hair back into two tight buns at the back of her head; two long and thick golden locks framed her face as she forcibly strained to see into the distance.

Out we go, past the river, and on to the Ravanok-grass sea we will goo… she began to sing in her head before taking note of the pressure building behind her eyes.

Wait… Oww, "eeee!" squeaked from her lips.

Kara straightened out momentarily before relaxing again as the pressure subsided.

I can't say I really understood what Maester Tolbin said that this would feel like… He kind of mumbled a lot in his later years. By the time we got to him, well…

He had this… this hand… A hand on a stick. He used it to gesticulate wildly as he rambled on about current events. Stories of white envelopes with white powder, something about Ganja-Ganja preceding Manja-Manja. I don't think I learned so much, and so little at the same time.

I can just imagine, the years and years of Citadel Cadets grinding at your sanity. I suppose I might have stories, and a hand too, after a while.

Kàra shuddered.

I can tell you this though… Suddenly having someone in your head is weird…. Someone to hear your inner thoughts and nigh a moment of reprieve…

Kàra furrowed her brow, I am sure there is a way to…

Kara placed two fingers on her left temple and closed her eyes. There just seems to be some sort of feedback between us. I can feel… it.

"Oww!" She exclaimed and winced.

Kara quickly placed her index finger and thumb across her forehead.

She winced again.

Interpreter? Are you still there? Did I lose you?

Nope… I can still feel you like a Fluvian ear worm.

Her concentration shifted to the formidably sized and brilliantly polished suit of armor clanking up the sandy red rock path leading to the gates below. Kàra smirked as she heard an audible clank coming from a distance.

Bófreor… Where… are…

Kàra felt a sharp pain radiate from temple to temple.

Owwwwww…

Kàra paused, and gently pressed her thumbs against the inner portion of each eye socket. The bridge of her nose squeezed and white orbs fill her vision. Kàra held herself motionless while a dull white glow waxed and waned quickly beneath her thumbs. Feeling relief, she brought her palms up and rubbed her eyes.

That is much better… I think.

Hopefully that will last. Either way we're in the wind five and five!

Satisfied with the improvement, Kàra turned and burst through the double wood framed glass doors and into a cluttered, but empty study that sat atop a tall tower, above the southwestern gate. A musty smell immediately filled her nose, causing her to contort her face. She

began breathing through her mouth and continued to the window adjacent to the, also cluttered, commandant's desk.

Kàra put her right hand on the edge of the splintered wood frame and pushed on the heavy stained-glass window. Once open she leaned halfway out, calling down to the gates below, "Major, I want second company to assist as well. Have them rendezvous with Talik's knights near the mill. See if we can't keep a strong funnel into the knights."

"But..." A gruff voice shot back, Kàra cut him off finishing, "See if you can't again, try to convince Talik to send a few of her knights towards the ruins. Even if she spared a platoon, or two, it could be enough to avert a massacre of these people's cultural heritage..."

Kàra casually pushed herself back into the study without waiting for a response but hearing a gruff, "Aye." was enough confirmation.

As I was saying... She grabbed a green apple from the worn wooden fruit bowl near the commandant's desk. She began to thumb the surface, gently pressing her thumb into its flesh. After a few moments she found a clean bit of her tunic and wiped the apple.

I would argue that much of what the karak's do is for show, but not in the "I will clean up for you kind of way..."

No, they do smaller things... For example, this "commanding" officer's desk...

As Kàra spun the high back of the commanders chair a foul smell crept up and swirled each time she spun the chair.

The apples are no doubt an attempt to curry favor so we might look the other way should the need be. I mean come on. Apples? Really?

Gah... She tossed her apple into the air as she paced.

I'm not going to turn down an apple, but if they think a bowl of fruit is going to make me forget about their countries worst kept secret...

Kàra snatched her apple from the air, took a bite, dropped her hand to the desk, uncurled her fingers, and drug them through the parchment. She could feel the apple's juices leave a sticky trail along her hand ending up as blots along the parchment as she searched.

In this greed and lust filled land, there are so many hints of culture, moments of greatness, and they are all hidden...

Hidden behind relics of the past. Never before have we been here, in this moment. And for the karak's to cling to the sand and the literal hole in the ground lairs of depravity. Well...

She swiped her hand through the parchment knocking a bunch of papers on the floor.

How do apples make up for the roving bands of constables sweeping people off the street, raiding orphanages and the like, all to please their select clientele from far off reaches...

Kàra pulled at a few desk drawers.

Their military is deep in the trade, and they profit just as much as the slavers, if not more for their "procurement" of foreign... product.

Kàra drew in a slow and deliberate breath and started to pace around the Karak's desk. Each path a slight variation on the last leading from the balcony back to the stained glass window. She liked to spend ample time at the balcony keeping watch, but she knew boredom would creep in if she let it. So she decided to break into the Karak's desk.

What? Just a little peek won't hurt. Just a little peek here, and there. A little locked drawer there.

Hmmm mmm what have we got here?

Kàra pulled on a knob on one of the lower drawers kicking open a compartment at the bottom of the desk. A quick mechanical whirr and something hit the floor with a thud. Kàra took another bite of her apple and placed it firmly on the desk. She then knelt down so she could take a look.

Are you... Wow! That got so good.

She sat back up licking her lips.

It got so much better! Wow.

Kàra bent over and reached underneath.

So, Interpreter are you ready for an adventure?

You can hear me, I know you can, I can feel your presence listening in. And as I said earlier, this is not quite what they had described back at the Citadel, but I can tell. Kàra tapped the side of her temple with her free hand and cleared her throat, still attempting to grab the object that fell. Stupid thing is so far back.

As it was witnessed by her holiness Valfreyja, and as etched upon every watcher stone in the realm. An account Odinn's judgement, and Mjölnir's fury...

Kàra casually pointed towards the east, and towards a massive cloudbank off in the distance.

"Ugh" Kàra said in disgust as she pressed herself to the ground so she could see where her hand was.

I mean, hey, it is pretty clear you aren't wanted when your planet gives birth to massive islands in the sky.

Upon finally spying her prize, Kàra reached in snatching it up. She tried not to think about the things on the floor. It is the crunchy ones that get me. She stood up and looked down at her upper body, hastily smacking the dirt from herself.

But it was the destruction of the Bifrost...

Nobody could leave. On the frontier, riding the edge of the universe into the expanse.

Valfreyja's account has little detail of our ancestors transgressions, but it goes into great detail of the battle that preceded its destruction, ending with the spectral bridge collapsing at her feet.

Kàra stood up shaking the little box before tossing it onto the desk. She said she could see Heimdallr turn his back as Thor hurled his hammer through the cosmos.

Upon striking our world, well, I am glad that Valfreyja was with us that day. Can you imagine if she wasn't? I guarantee our world is not supposed to exist. We were to be struck from the galactic forum, permanently. That is the day the Vanir and Æsir officially went to war.

Kàra opened the box and furrowed her brow. Strange. She pulled out a small, folded up sketch. Looks to be the works of a child. She folded it back up and placed the lid back on the box.

But it is pretty hard to engage in a war when you have no way of reaching your adversary. So, we, meaning our long-lost ancestors, we made do. Refugees of the nine realms. We are destined to fade from history.

Kàra could feel the ground beneath her shift, a few books shifted on their shelves. Nothing fell, nothing to worry about.

Peoples from every realm were now suddenly residents of this new frontier. Without the Bifrost, colonization felt impractical, causing some to turn on each other. Boundaries were drawn immediately, roving bands establishing and fortifying borders. Wars were fought over old wounds and new.

Little is known of, or maybe more appropriately, left from those times though. Valfreyja was relentless in the pursuit of her vision, she was beyond determined to persevere no matter what it took.

I read that she wandered these lands for generations, searching for others who would listen. Relationship after relationship, she connected with the people, and convinced them that her vision was enough.

Kàra made her way to the stained-glass window and began to move it back and forth. She watched as people busily bustled in and out of the gates below.

Eventually people flocked to her, and to what is now Midgard. I tell you though... When Mjölnir fractured Heim... it didn't just destroy the Bifrost. It broke a lot of people. Trapped in a land they had never intended on settling.

Kàra plopped down in the chair behind the desk. A poof of dust shot up out of the chair. She reached forward and grabbed her apple, letting the chair catch her as she leaned back and stretched out her

crossed legs. Kàra closed her eyes and tried to take in the feeling of the warm air whisking through the study.

Kàra took a bite and savored the flavor this time.

Valfreyja wrote of her experience: "Mjölnir revealed to me Odinn's judgement upon our peoples. Ragnarök.

Should Yggdrasil guide you to my hall.

Upon its roots should we shall surrender

By the interpreters will, we shall fight.

We will not go quietly.

Till Ragnarök we meet...

Valfreyja took that personally,

her feelings quite clear:

We shall not yield.

Beyond the reach of Odinn

We shall rebuild.

Beyond the sight of Heimdallr

We shall prosper.

Time will not be kind to those who see only the old ways.

Kàra pushed the chair away from the desk and towards the window behind her. She spun about taking another smaller bite from her apple. She felt slightly sad that she was almost finished with it.

Midgard spring up around what came to be known as the Citadel: a sprawling military academy, which housed the first of Valfreya's disciples.

Her curation of its archives, er. The hall of letters, propelled the peoples of Midgard into the forefront of Heim's geopolitical problems.

There are countless writings, all from Valfreyja's hand. It is like being able to touch a piece of her when you go there... She was obsessed with unlocking the secrets of our world... Of the cosmos. All so that, we, her peoples, could one day return to the galactic forum.

She opened her eyes and lazily brought her apple up, looked for a good spot and took a bite.

You should be honored.

Honestly, not because you are in my head of all places, but the fact that the Ætherial tendrils of Yggdrasil have reached out across the planes of existence, to connect our two realms. Our two minds. Across space, and time, your realm linked with mine, it may just be for the briefest of moments, but it is no less **important.**

I guess...

Kàra bit the inside of her lower lip.

I guess I am flattered to be one of the chosen. The hall of letters speaks of countless encounters, beings from across existences sharing a moment in time with ours. It is kind of like a multi-dimensional root system filling our prismatic void that the Bifrost once did.

We are taught, at the academy that is, that existence is fleeting. An experience, a moment that only exists because we are having it. Always operating within shifting boundaries. Maximizing relative comfort between what is known and unknown. The only thing truly moving forward is our generational knowledge. It is therefore our duty to be good stewards of society, guiding it, helping it to be better than what it was, to guard her from harm.

Kàra let her legs drop, and she leaned forward.

The Citadel archives seem to be a bit incomplete as to the specifics of each of the chosen's journey though... as many who join the journey, well... Generally they do not finish... But, I mean... stories have passed down through the centuries. So I am sure there must be some exceptions.

Right?

Many of those on the Ætherial Council, have spent their entire careers trying to understand Valfreyja, and Yggdrasil's divine will. The fracturing didn't just strand our peoples here. It also created rifts in the fabric of the cosmos. Rifts that generally liquify people, but those things. The Skripi. They came pouring out.

Kàra pushed herself up to her feet and leisurely walked over to a window adjacent the balcony doors.

My tour in the archives has taught me two things about our situation: This is now a journey shared, i.e., this is a journey that we undertake, 'til

Ragnarök do us part. Whether fate is what we make it. Well. I guess Yggdrasil has yet to decide.

Kàra spun about making her skirt spin slightly.

The Ælves, Dwarves, the peoples of Midgard, and various others, recognized the Skripi, as creatures posing an existential threat to all peoples across Heim. Those that didn't, Kàra stuck out her index finger from atop her folded arms, pointing away from her body. Reclaimed by the wild.

The majority though opened their eyes, and minds, to the idea of peace. Or at least uneasy truces. One in which for the first time, established the council.

Kàra began to gesticulate as she recited the moto by heart: "Ten members. Ten different cultures. Ten equals. Do you have what it takes to become a citizen?" Kàra ended it with a campy, but dignified salute.

I wouldn't be here if I didn't believe in what the council was doing... So... Yeah. Now that we got the run down of me and mine, you have joined me at, what I personally feel is a most interesting time. We are readying for a Skrípi invasion, and they are due here any time. But I guess you probably picked up on that.

Kàra yawned.

Oh, I can tell ya the Skrípi are these pretty nasty armored spider like creatures, and I am certain they are not looking for a handout. I mean.

Maybe they are?

I don't know, they are, and honestly the easiest way to explain it is that these creatures have one mission, and that is...

Ya know...

Feed us to their brood. And I can tell you... She took a smaller bite from her ripening apple.

If you are drug off alive, your death is excruciatingly slow. The young like to play with their food. I have heard of survivors that lasted three days before their escape. None have ever been the same again. Walking nightmares that follow them wherever they go.

She took another large bite, savoring the juices this time. The white flesh of the apple began to redden significantly. She took a last bite and tossed the apple out the window.

Wow, I can't believe that was so good. Almost a metallic tang to it at the end. I don't know how they do it out here, a touch of sweet, and a touch of sour.

But, wow. Kara grabbed another few apples and slipped them into her pouch where they seemed to simply disappear.

So anyways... My job here is to toss a spanner into the works. I swore an oath to stand for justice for those we love. And in the name of Folkenvangar: I am going to teach them a lesson.

No.

That doesn't work.

I need to get better at these.